

by Gyana Swain

OpenAI targets heavy users with premium ChatGPT Business seats

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Analysts say enterprise AI vendors are redesigning pricing models to better monetise high-intensity and agentic workloads.



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OpenAI is introducing a higher-priced “Premium” tier for its ChatGPT Business offering, allowing enterprises to assign higher-capacity access to select users alongside standard licences – a move analysts said is about enterprise AI vendors redesigning pricing to capture more value from high-intensity workloads.

The company said the new tier provides “5x more usage than Standard” and “removes the five-hour usage limit,” enabling users to “take on larger projects and work with fewer interruptions.”

“Premium seats cost \$125 per user per month, or \$100 per user per month when billed annually,” OpenAI said in a **statement** [<https://openai.com/index/premium-seats-chatgpt-business/>]. “Standard seats remain \$25 per user per month, or \$20 per user per month when billed annually.”

OpenAI said enterprises can “mix Standard and Premium seats across the same team” and “upgrade or reassign seats as business needs change,” with administrators able to “monitor usage across the workspace” and “manage billing, usage, and spend limits in one place.”

Vendors converge on seat-plus-usage pricing

Analysts said the introduction of a higher-capacity tier reflects a broader shift toward hybrid pricing models.

“Read this as vendors converging on a two-layer bill rather than abandoning flat pricing,” said Bhupendra Chopra, chief revenue officer at Kanerika. “There’s a predictable per-seat charge for everyday chat, and a separate metered charge for heavy agentic work.”

Chopra said vendors are packaging this differently. “Google bundles the first into Workspace and meters the second. Microsoft folds Copilot into its bundles and sells credit packs for agent runs. OpenAI has no productivity suite to hide the seat cost inside, so it built a higher seat tier instead.”

That model is reflected in current offerings. Microsoft 365 Copilot **pricing** [<https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/microsoft-365-copilot/pricing>] positions Copilot as a per-user add-on to Microsoft 365, while Google Gemini enterprise pricing shows model and agent usage billed separately from Workspace plans. Anthropic’s Claude pricing similarly outlines subscription tiers alongside usage-based model access.

For CIOs, this changes how AI spending is managed, Chopra said. “Your AI budget now has a fixed component and a variable one, and they need different owners. Seat count is a procurement problem. Metered spend is a FinOps problem.”

Premium seats target high-usage workloads

OpenAI said Premium seats are designed for “your most active teammates,” citing use cases such as “organizing inventory,” “building marketing campaigns,” and “analyzing business performance.”

The company said Premium users can “take on bigger projects and keep work moving,” with “predictable weekly usage resets” and the option to add “shared workspace credits” if limits are reached.

Analysts said this reflects a shift in how enterprise AI usage is being monetized.

“This is not vendors admitting that flat seats failed. It is vendors admitting that one seat no longer describes one economic profile,” said Sanchit Vir Gogia, chief analyst at Greyhound Research. “The seat is the engine an enterprise licenses. The fuel is now billed separately.”

Gogia added that vendors are structuring pricing differently around that model. “OpenAI has kept a fixed seat and meters what sits above it. Microsoft has kept a \$30 Copilot licence carrying no entitlement to its agentic layer at all. Google, meanwhile, has left its seat editions alone while switching agent meters on by published date.”

Greyhound Research pointed to the treatment of usage caps as a signal of how capacity is being priced.

“Most will read this as segmentation. Greyhound Research reads it as rationing, and the five-hour limit is the tell,” Gogia said. “On July 12, OpenAI removed that limit free of charge. At the end of July, it was restored. On August 10, it became a paid entitlement.”

CIOs face allocation and cost decisions

The higher-priced tier raises questions about how enterprises assign access, analysts said.

“Don’t start with people. Start with your billing data,” Chopra said. “If someone is regularly drawing down shared workspace credits, a fixed higher seat may cost less and forecast better than open-ended credit consumption.”

He said allocation based on hierarchy can lead to inefficiencies. “You end up paying premium rates for executives who open it twice a week while the analyst-blocked mid-close stays throttled.”

Gogia echoed that view. “Power user should describe a workload pattern, not a job title,” he said. “The right question is whose work becomes materially more valuable when Standard stops being enough.”

Credits positioned to drive metered usage

According to the statement, OpenAI is offering incentives, stating that eligible customers can receive “\$100 worth of workspace credits (2,500 credits) for each Premium seat they

add, up to 5 seats.”

Analysts said such credits are tied to usage-based pricing. “Worth being clear that this isn’t a discount. Credits are currency inside OpenAI’s metered layer,” Chopra said. “Free credits get a workspace comfortable for consuming metered features,” Gogia said the offer should be treated as a pilot incentive. “The promotion should fund the pilot. It should not shorten the runway,” Gogia said, adding that billing controls, including pooled credits and auto-recharge settings, require close oversight.

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